

Bottomless Pits

We didn't have time to write a leader because we spent one hour deciding what to order for dinner...

Oh no! Here they come again, like a horde of hungry monsters, hooting and screaming like the Cro Magnon man attacking prehistoric cattle. Why me? Why do I have to put up with them?

It's bad enough they make all this noise, but like clockwork they seem to celebrate this stupid monthly festival called 'issue closing'.

It's another 10 days of torture. Ten days of polluting the atmosphere, dropping disgusting things all over the place (mostly on me), and 10 more torturous days of listening to inane conversations about stupid things called computers and philosophy.

Here comes that rounded thing called 'Srini', though I've heard him being addressed as Srinivasan before.



He's the sloppiest, and messes up my beautiful brown coat with the precision of Tiger Woods hitting a hole-in-one. He's arguing with that queer looking fellow with the shiny head. What was his name again?... 'Raaabo' or 'Robert' or something... He's the one with the tool called 'bike', which everyone is always begging him to use.

"Come on man, I'm tired of that pizza guy. Let's get some real food for a change. Let's order from McDonald's," bellows Srini. "No way man, I ain't goin' that way again. Last time I spent 160 bucks for that flat tyre, and no one wants to shell out any dough for it," yells Raaabo. They both leave, thankfully, still yelling.

Aw shucks, it's only been 10 minutes and the next bunch of jokers is back. There's the podgy one called 'Upendra', the white, tall, slender one called 'Garfield', the one with the funny curvy

design called 'Mitali', and that infernal duo of Srini and Raaabo.

Raaabo has this horrible habit called 'smoking', which pollutes the air around me and leaves this grey dust all over the place.

They're all talking about that gunk called 'food', each one trying to get in an opinion edgeways, and screaming their lungs out.

"Let's have Punjabi food," yells Upendra.

"No, I want pizza," screams Mitali.

"You just want to order from that pizza guy because he has a crush on you, and gives you loads of freebies," says Srini.

At this point, Mitali takes off her slipper and chases Srini in circles around me.

"Why don't we make Mitali order for all of us, and share the freebies," says Garfield.

"Great idea", "Wunderbar", "Let's do it", echo the mindless drones.

Raaabo promptly blows a puff of smoke at me, flicks his cigarette in the general direction of the ashtray, completely misses and gets ash all over me. Oh well! Better than last night when he 'accidentally' stubbed a lit cigarette on me. Soon they all leave, and I have my few minutes of peace.

It's about an hour later, and they all come back carrying little packets of that deadly substance called food. Looks like most of them ordered pizza—that's ok, not to messy.

Oh no, here come Srini and Upendra carrying Punjabi food, with (gasp!) gravy. Man I hate issue closing! For nine hours a day I have to tolerate noise and second-hand smoke, and now for the next 240 hours, the nights won't be peaceful either.

"How much is the bill?," asks Raaabo. "A cool 721 bucks man," whines Upendra. "Srini go bug 'deep pockets' to pay the bill," suggests Mitali. "No way!

man, he'll kill me this time, I swear. We already owe him like over 1,000 bucks—and that's just for this month," complains Srini.

Like fuel to a fire, Sachin 'deep pockets' Kalbag (SK) is the cause of my misery. If it wasn't for him, these slobs wouldn't have the 'bucks' to buy food, and I would be saved a lot of mental anguish.

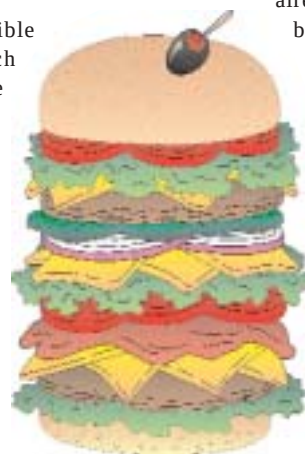
I have learnt from their conversations that he always pays all, or most of the bucks, and the monsters never pay him back.

It's obvious he hates me!

SK paid the bill again. I would commit suicide; if only I knew how. There's mindless chitter-chatter for five minutes, while I can hear tearing noises of plastic and foil, and then, silence!

The only sounds are the gnawing on flesh, the slurping of fingers, the crunch of pizza crusts and the scraping of spoons against plastic. Each one of them is trying to do too many things at once.

Mitali wants to proof an article, while boasting about how the pizza guy gave more stuff free this time and stuffing her mouth with a salad.



Raaabo insists on smoking when eating, and drops sauce on me, blows smoke in my direction and stubs his cigarette out on my leg.

Srini and Upendra are playing the 'look-I-can-stuff-more-in-my-mouth' game, and dropping *makhanwala* gravy on me all the time.

SK just cannot live without caramel custard, and has to share it with me... by dropping the sugar water on me. Why are they always in a hurry? Who is this strange and invisible god called 'reader' they always want to please? Why don't I just get up and walk out?

Perhaps it's because I'm a lost soul damned to eternity sitting in the 'Smoker's / Hogger's bay', disguised as the table! ■